wrote Ensign Greville Stapylton, ‘being all in Afghan costume with long beards, moustaches. It was with some difficulty that one could recognise one’s friends.’[84]

The Army of Retribution stayed in Kabul for only two weeks. For the first few days, the troops amused themselves with eating fresh grapes and apples from the Kabul vineyards and orchards, and by visiting the sights of the town. Many sought out the sites where atrocities had taken place the previous winter. Those who had known Kabul during the occupation were especially shocked. ‘Great and terrible changes had taken place in my absence,’ wrote the artist James Rattray. ‘Razed houses and blackened walls met my view. No one appeared. The city was deserted, its habitations darkened and empty. We rode through the streets without encountering a living soul, or hearing a single sound, save the yelp of a half-wild dog who had lapped up English blood perchance, our own suppressed voices and the echoes of our horses’ hoofs sent back through the long grim avenues of the closed bazaars.’[85] Neville Chamberlain had last been to Alexander Burnes’s house during his Christmas party in 1839 when Burnes had appeared in full Highland dress and danced reels on a table top in his kilt. Now the house had been burned to the ground and its charred foundations had been dug up by treasure hunters. ‘Sir Alexander’s house, where I had spent many a happy hour, was a heap of ruins,’ wrote Chamberlain in his journal. ‘The cantonments were a perfect waste, and where so much money had been spent, not a house or barrack or tree was left.’[86]

Hugh Johnson was even more shocked: ‘On passing the corner of the street where I formerly lived I could not forego the desire of looking on the ruins of a house in which I had passed a period of 2 years of happiness,’ he wrote in his journal immediately after his return to Kabul. ‘Although I had expected to see the whole place unroofed I was not prepared for such a scene of desolation. Not one brick was left standing on another in either my house or that of Sir Alexander Burnes adjoining it. They were nothing but a heap of dirt covering the mouldering remains of our unfortunate people. A spot was pointed out to me in Sir Alexander’s garden as that in which his body had been interred. Peace to his ashes!’[87]

More heartbreaking still was the sight of the maimed and crippled sepoys who had somehow managed to survive the winter by begging in the streets of Kabul. The more conscientious officers now threw their energies into trying to reassemble what was left of their regiments: the most successful